

GORGONZOLA & PANCETTA MAC N CHEESE

INGREDIENTS

240g short-cut pasta
kosher salt and freshly-ground black pepper
½ cup Panko breadcrumbs
¼ cup plus 2 tablespoons Parmesan cheese, divided
½ cup crumbled Blue Cheese
2 cups shredded Fontina
1/2 cup half and half
2 cups whole milk
3 tablespoons all purpose flour
1 large leek (white and light green parts only), washed thoroughly and cut into thin slices
120g diced pancetta
5 tablespoons unsalted butter , divided, plus additional for buttering ramekins or baking dish
chopped parsley or snipped chives , for garnish

INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Preheat oven to 200C with rack in middle position. Butter a baking dish, or six. Place on a baking sheet and set aside.

Step 2: Mix Panko, 1 tablespoon melted butter, 2 tablespoons Parmesan, and a pinch of salt and pepper in a small bowl. Set aside.

Step 3: Cook pasta to "al-dente" in a large pot of salted boiling water. Reserve 1 cup of the pasta water before draining well.

Step 4: While bringing your pasta water to a boil, melt 4 tablespoons of butter in a large, heavy-bottomed pot until foaming subsides. Add pancetta and cook over medium-high heat until fat is rendered and pancetta is just beginning to crisp.

Step 5: Add leeks, ½ teaspoon each kosher salt and black pepper to the pot. Cook until leeks are softened, about 5 minutes. Reduce heat and continue cooking, stirring often, until leeks are very soft and caramelized, about 15 minutes longer. Stir in flour and cook for 1 minute. Add milk and cream, stirring until sauce is smooth and thickened, about 3 minutes. Whisk in Fontina, Gorgonzola, and ¼ cup Parmesan. Season to taste with additional salt and pepper.

Step 6: Add cooked pasta to the cheese sauce, stirring until well combined. Stir in enough pasta water to make the sauce creamy, but not thin and watery (I usually add about ¼ cup). Transfer pasta to prepared baking dishes and top with breadcrumb mixture.

Step 7: Bake 15-20 minutes, until sauce is bubbly and breadcrumbs are toasted. Sprinkle with parsley or chives, if desired, and serve hot.

THE COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef